



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

na tv eva kuryād ātmānaṃ devīm vā lakṣyam īśvaraḥ | KAZ01.10.17ab
śauca.hetor amātyānām etat kauṭilya.darśanam || 17 || KAZ01.10.17cd
na dūṣaṇam aduṣṭasya viṣeṇa-iva-ambhasaś caret | KAZ01.10.18ab
kadācidd hi praduṣṭasya na-adhigamyeta bheṣajam || 18 || KAZ01.10.18cd

— Arthaśāstra, Chapter 10 (Section 6): Ascertainment of the Integrity of Ministers by Means of Secret Tests (Chapter 10), Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

Kautilya's wisdom here delves into the delicate balance of leadership and trust, specifically concerning the selection and testing of ministers. The scripture advises that the ruler, representing power itself, should not make themselves or the goddess (representing the kingdom's fortune) the target of integrity tests. Kautilya suggests that testing ministers for purity is essential, but it should never involve compromising the sanctity of the leadership or the kingdom's well-being. This is Kautilya's view, his "darśanam".

The text further warns against unjustly accusing someone who is innocent, likening it to poisoning pure water. If you wrongly taint an honest minister with suspicion, you risk damaging their integrity and loyalty, potentially making them resentful. The analogy highlights the irreversible nature of such damage. Just as poison contaminates water, false accusations can corrupt a person's character.

Conversely, the scripture acknowledges that sometimes, a truly corrupt individual may be difficult to detect. It states that "kadācidd hi praduṣṭasya na-adhigamyeta bheṣajam" implying that sometimes the "medicine" or remedy for a corrupt person is not discoverable.

In modern life, this translates to the importance of due diligence and careful consideration when evaluating individuals in positions of power. As a leader, you should be discerning in your judgment, avoiding hasty accusations that could irreparably harm reputations and morale. The passage serves as a reminder that trust is a valuable asset, and once broken, it can be challenging to rebuild. Your approach to testing and assessing individuals should be thoughtful and strategic, aiming to identify genuine integrity without causing unnecessary damage. It invites you to reflect on the methods you use to ascertain the integrity of those around you. The Arthaśāstra advocates for wisdom and prudence in all dealings, and this passage exemplifies that principle.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

How can you apply the wisdom of Kautilya to foster a culture of trust and accountability in your own sphere of influence, ensuring that integrity is valued without resorting to methods that could be destructive?